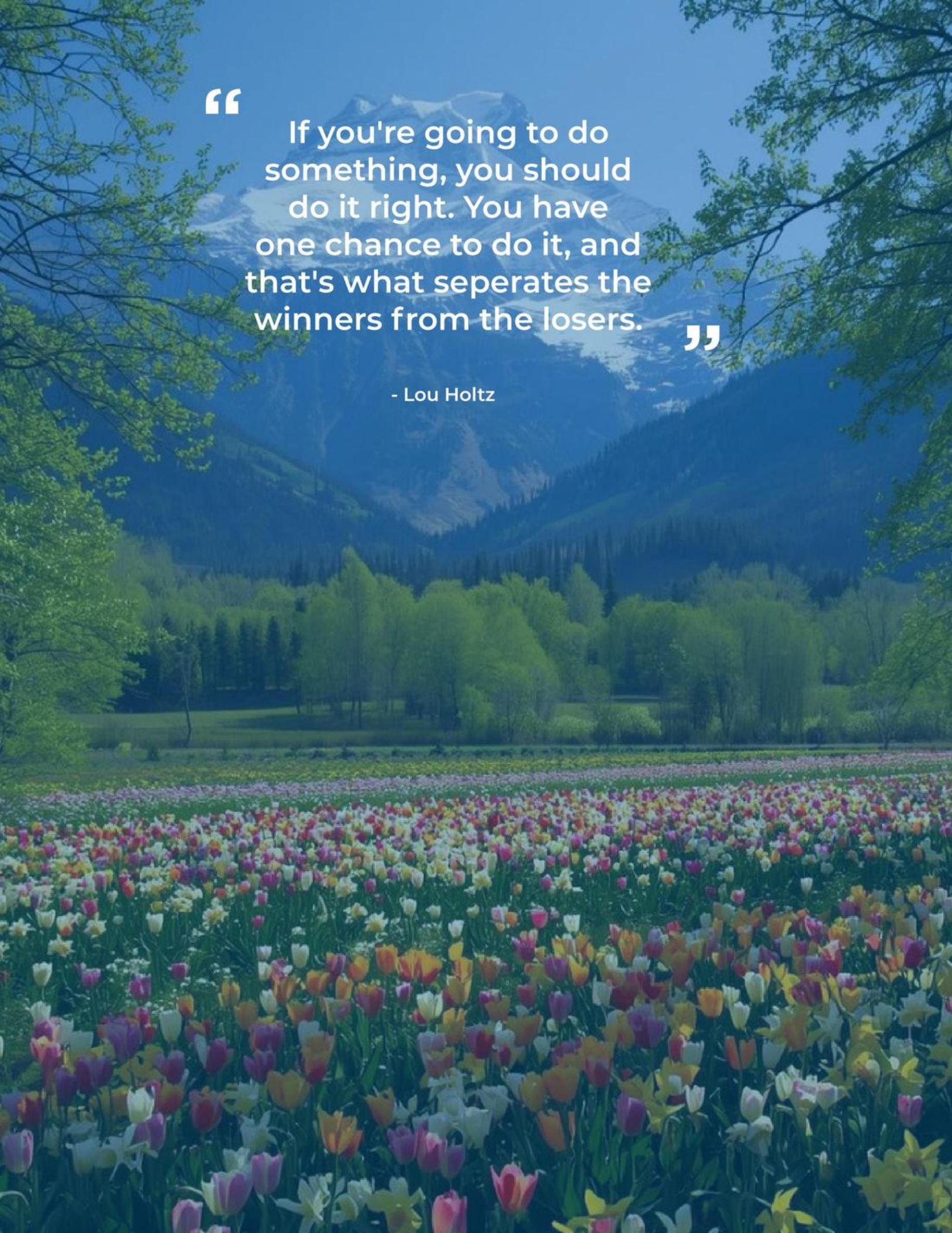


VISTA UNPLUGGED

SPRING 2026


“
If you're going to do something, you should do it right. You have one chance to do it, and that's what seperates the winners from the losers.
”
- Lou Holtz

A Message From Jeff

Dear friends,

Spring is here, the days are stretching longer, green shoots are breaking through, and that sense of fresh beginnings feels especially welcome after winter; not that we received much snow this year. In southwest Colorado, this winter ranks up there with the most mild ever on record. We are Really hoping mother nature blesses us with a record spring snowfall.

2025 tested us with real headwinds: tariff uncertainties, the long government shutdown, geopolitical tensions, and those early sharp drops that kept headlines full of worry.

Yet the markets showed remarkable resilience. U.S. stocks delivered another year of solid gains, fueled by innovation and earnings strength in tech and AI. Even more encouraging, international markets came alive with stronger returns in many regions—thanks to better company results, currency shifts, and renewed interest—serving as a powerful reminder of diversification and patience.

Markets rarely move in straight lines, but they often reward staying the course through the noise. Just as harsh winters give way to spring's vitality, last year's foundation feels like it's setting us up for more opportunity ahead.

Early signs for 2026 suggest continued earnings momentum and a supportive environment—though we'll navigate the usual uncertainties. What matters most isn't forecasting every turn; it's remembering what is most important in our lives.

This spring is a great time to renew in our financial lives too—revisiting goals, tweaking portfolios if needed, or simply reconnecting with your long-term vision. I'm grateful to be part of yours.

Thank you for your trust and for letting me walk this path with you. I look forward to our conversations in these brighter days.

With Gratitude,

Jeff Speicher, AIF®
Founder - Managing Director



JEFF SPEICHER
FINANCIAL ADVISOR

VISTA UNPLUGGED NEWS

What's Inside:

Reintroducing Our Growing Team

Suggested Reading Idea

Two Simple Rules That Guide Everything We Do for Our Clients

The Wallet and The Word

Celebrating Team Growth, Fresh Insights, and Grace's Operational Rookie of the Year Honor – All for You, Our Valued Clients

The $24 Manhattan Myth: Why Compound Interest Might Have Made the Lenape the Long-Term "Winners"

Overcoming Tax Anxiety: Strategies for a Calmer Tax Season

Dow 100,000? Is That Possible?

Recipe Corner

Newsletter Disclosures

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Reintroducing Our Growing Team

Over the years, we've built strong, lasting relationships with savers and business owners—including agricultural operators across the Midwest and Southwest. These connections often span multiple generations, reflecting our genuine understanding of the unique demands and rewards of running a family farm or business. To meet those evolving needs, we're investing heavily in training and stand ready to expand as our client families grow.

We're especially excited to support the next generation as they navigate wealth stewardship, education, career transitions, and long-term planning. To that end, we're thrilled to welcome **Kyle Blair** to the team. Kyle brings fresh expertise, energy, and added capacity, enabling us to deliver the high-touch, personalized service our growing client families deserve.



Jeff Speicher, AIF® – Founder and Managing Director.
With over 20 years in financial services since 1998, Jeff leads with a client-first philosophy, crafting strategies that precisely align with individual needs and aspirations.



Laura Catton – Director of Client Services
In the industry since 2010, Laura is the operational backbone of the team. She handles client communications, account setups, and daily execution with exceptional detail, timeliness, and reliability. She is also our office plant whisperer.



Vinessa Ekberg – Client Service Specialist
Joined financial services in 2014. Focused on special events and client communication, Vinessa prioritizes what matters most to our clients: family, occupation, and recreation.



Grace Kline – Client Service Specialist
Joined in 2025, with a background in front-facing service, bringing enthusiasm and dedicated support to meet our clients' evolving needs.



Kyle Blair – Financial Advisor
A financial advisor since 2024 and Eagle Scout, Kyle's prior experience in mortgage lending honed his ability to navigate complex situations with swift, effective follow-through.

continued on pg. 6

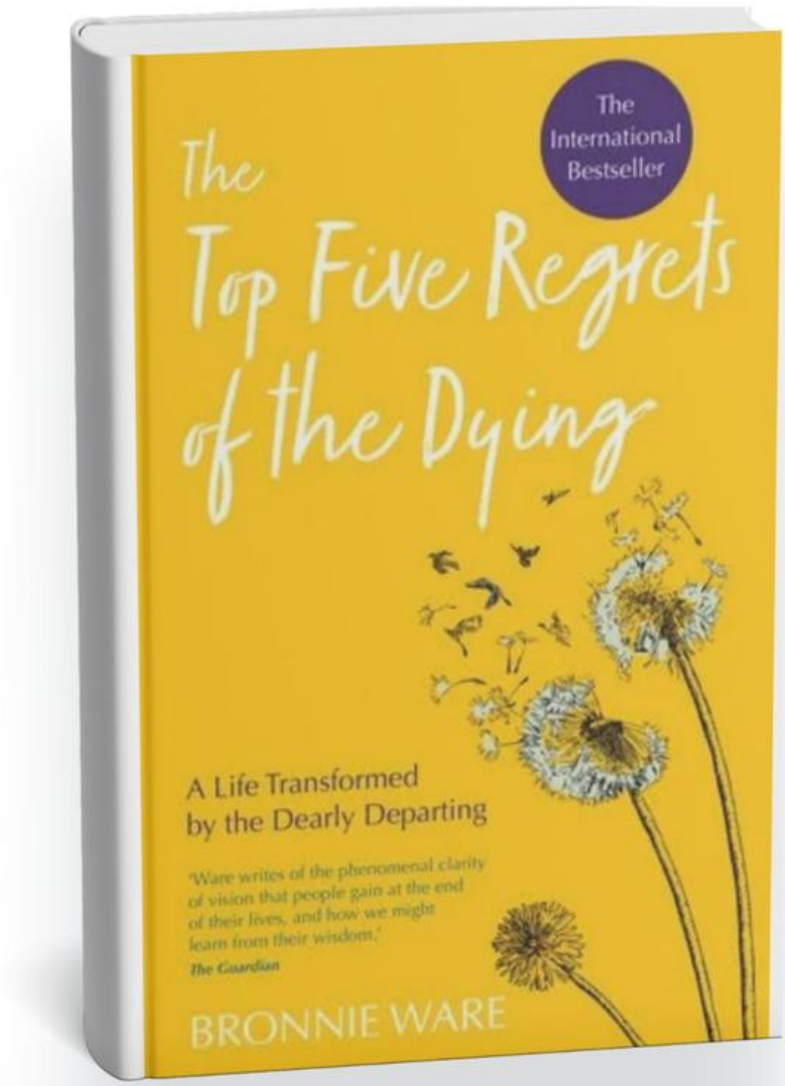
Our expanded, seasoned team is now better positioned than ever to guide families, cultivate enduring relationships, deliver proactive advice, and instill financial confidence for generations to come.

Kyle recently attended the Southern Rocky Mountain Ag Conference (February 3–5, 2026) in Colorado's San Luis Valley, connecting directly with potato growers and other agricultural producers in Monte Vista. This high-desert region remains a vital hub for potato and alfalfa production.

The visit reinforced our commitment to truly understanding the daily realities and challenges our farming families face. The San Luis Valley exemplifies broader agricultural struggles: extreme dependence on irrigation in a region receiving just 7–10 inches of annual rainfall, tightening water allocations amid declining snowpack and aquifer recharge, rising energy costs for pumping, and the shift toward sustainable practices like conservation and deficit irrigation to secure multigenerational viability. These local pressures compound with national market volatility, fluctuating prices, rising input costs, and trade uncertainties—demanding extraordinary resilience from family operations.



Spring Reading Idea



As spring 2026 blooms—starting March 20 with the vernal equinox—it's the perfect season for renewal, reflection, and setting intentions for a more authentic life. One timeless read to inspire that fresh start is **The Top Five Regrets of the Dying** by Bronnie Ware.

Originally a viral blog post, this heartfelt memoir draws from Ware's years in palliative care, where she listened to dying patients share their deepest regrets. What emerged were five strikingly consistent themes, not about achievements or possessions, but about missed opportunities for joy, connection, and truth.

The top five regrets:

1. **I wish I'd had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me.** The most common—many realized too late they'd sidelined dreams for approval.
2. **I wish I hadn't worked so hard.** Time lost to careers often meant missing family, health, and simple pleasures.
3. **I wish I'd had the courage to express my feelings.** Suppressed emotions breed resentment; honest words could have healed relationships.
4. **I wish I had stayed in touch with my friends.** Busy lives let precious bonds fade, only valued fully at the end.
5. **I wish I had let myself be happier.** Happiness was a choice many postponed, trapped by fear or habit.

Ware interweaves her own transformation—from corporate burnout to meaningful caregiving—showing how these insights reshaped her life toward courage, balance, and joy. The book is uplifting rather than somber: a gentle nudge to prioritize what truly matters while there's still time.

In spring 2026, as nature awakens, pick up this short, powerful read. It invites you to shed old patterns, nurture relationships, and choose authenticity now—so you can one day look back with peace, not regret. Highly recommended for anyone seeking clarity and renewal this season.

Two Simple Rules That Guide Everything We Do for Our Clients

In over 28 years of helping people plan their financial futures, I've distilled our philosophy down to **two unbreakable rules**—rules worth revisiting often. They center on what matters most: **Family, your work,** and **your recreation.** Money is simply the tool—the "how"—to protect and enjoy those priorities. No complex formulas or market tricks—just clear promises we make to every client and to ourselves.

Rule #1: You are not allowed to run out of money.
Running out in retirement brings stress, dependence, lost independence, and hardship for you and your loved ones. I've seen it happen—not from permanent market crashes, but from overlooking sequence risk, inflation, healthcare costs, or early over-withdrawal.

We treat "not running out" as non-negotiable. It shapes every decision:

- Portfolios and withdrawals designed for longevity, not just average returns.
- Stress-testing against poor return sequences, high inflation, and longer lifespans.
- Buffers for long-term care, volatility, and taxes.
- Ongoing reviews and adjustments—because life evolves.

The goal isn't the largest nest egg at death; it's the confidence your money outlasts you, freeing you to stop worrying and start living. A client going broke on my watch? Not happening.

Rule #2: You are not allowed to reach the end with a long list of regrets.
This life is a **one-shot deal**—no do-overs. Too many reach later years financially secure but emotionally empty, wishing they'd prioritized family time, meaningful work, recreation, travel, or experiences instead of always playing it safe.

Hoarding out of fear fuels those regrets. Bronnie Ware's The Top Five Regrets of the Dying (from her palliative care experience) shows the most common aren't about money or work



hours—they're about not living true to yourself, overworking at the expense of relationships, suppressing feelings, losing touch with friends and family, and not allowing yourself to be happier. In short: not prioritizing what truly matters.

Our planning goes beyond spreadsheets:

- What experiences matter most—for family, work passions, recreation—now and in the future?
- Where do you want to go, who do you want to see, what do you want to try while healthy?
- How can we fund those priorities without risking Rule #1?

We champion "permission-based spending": intentional enjoyment along the way. A dream family trip in your 60s? A passion project or hobby business? Early semi-retirement for volunteering or hobbies? If it's sustainable, we're not just okay with it—we'll encourage you to make it happen. Like Carol, who bought that electric bike she's wanted for years, or our farmer brothers who now take those long-awaited hunting trips together.

The Sweet Spot: Balancing the Rules

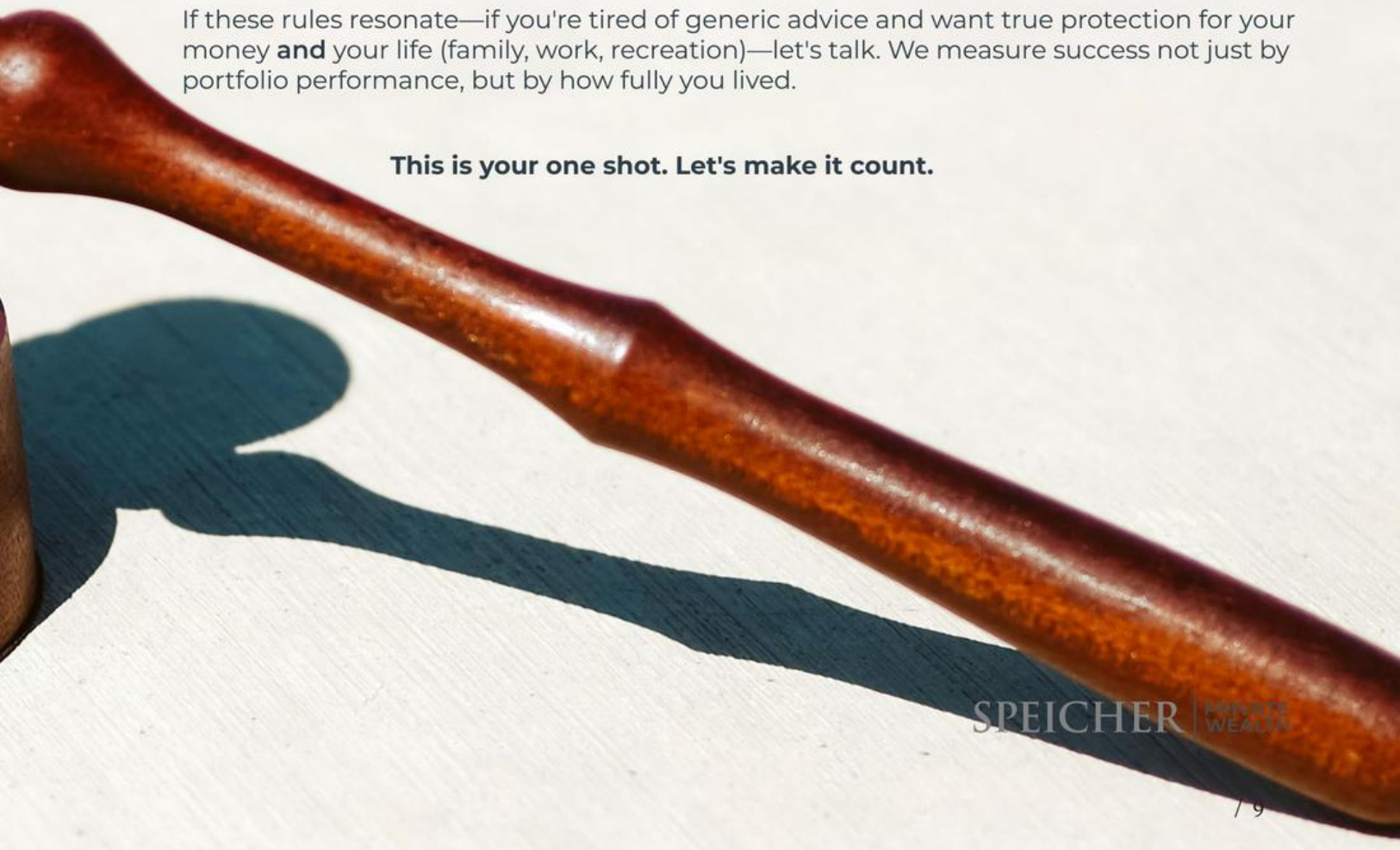
They may seem at odds—"don't run out" vs. "don't waste your one life." The power lies in balance:

- Secure the basics so worry disappears.
- Spend enough to build memories, strengthen family bonds, find fulfillment in work and recreation, and live regret-free.
- Ideally, die with no unnecessary dollars left unspent on what mattered most.

We call it **"regret-proof retirement"**—intentional living backed by disciplined planning, neither reckless nor overly conservative.

> If these rules resonate—if you're tired of generic advice and want true protection for your money **and** your life (family, work, recreation)—let's talk. We measure success not just by portfolio performance, but by how fully you lived.

This is your one shot. Let's make it count.



The Wallet and the Word

Last fall, my mom gave me a special gift: a cutting from my grandfather's Christmas cactus. Mom's took five years to bloom; ours, now in my office, nurtured by Laura, flowered in just a month. It is blooming again, so we think it might actually be an "Easter cactus"—but it was so darn pretty I had to share.

My grandfather, Wesley Paul Vitkus (1909–1978), was shaped by harder times. A World War II Staff Sergeant in the U.S. Army, he returned with a soldier's quiet discipline: duty first, complaints few.

He had a remarkable green thumb—coaxing vegetables from tough soil and keeping a neat lawn. Resourceful like many of his generation, he straightened bent nails and worked tirelessly: hunting, fishing, digging a well, or helping the neighbors from dawn to dusk. In 1953, he served as Master of Eagle Grange #1, showing his commitment to community and land. Evenings often found him on the porch in his worn straw hat, rocking slowly and spitting tobacco juice into the dust.

Mom always joked she wanted nothing from him when he passed—except his wallet. That old leather billfold was mysteriously always full of cash, no matter the season or hardship. He never boasted; it was simply there, ready to help quietly.

He loved blazing-hot horseradish—grated fresh, it cleared sinuses and brought tears. "Puts hair on your chest," he'd grin, watching my dad choke and laugh.

Above all, he was a man of integrity: his word was ironclad, no excuses, just reliability you could count on. Sadly, he passed away when I was only 8, but my parents gave me his old straw hat, and my son carries his name.

We named our son Wesley to honor his great-granddad. When I watch the boy work hard, fix things, or keep promises, I see Grandpop's quiet strength and determination shining through.

The straightened nails, full wallet, burning horseradish, and porch rituals live on in memory and in how we live—with honor and grit. Those are big shoes to fill, but I'd like to think his flowering cactus is his way of telling us he approves.



Celebrating Team Growth, Fresh Insights, and Grace's Operational Rookie of the Year Honor – All for You, Our Valued Clients



In 1982, Founded by three Texas Tech fraternity brothers, Prospera set out to become the gold standard for boutique financial advisors and their teams. Speicher Private Wealth proudly lives that vision: combining powerful institutional tools and resources with a genuine family atmosphere and a team fully invested in our shared success—and, most importantly, in delivering outstanding value to you.
Fresh from an inspiring few days at Prospera's headquarters in Dallas, Laura, Grace, and Vinessa returned energized and already putting new ideas into action. They proudly represented Speicher Private Wealth at the flagship **Sales Assistant University (SAU) 2026**, joining support professionals from across Prospera's nationwide network.

Over three intensive days, SAU delivered expert-led training on cutting-edge products and platforms, compliance best practices, client service excellence, operational efficiencies, and strategies to maximize productivity. Through keynotes, workshops, roundtables, and hands-on collaboration with Prospera's operations experts, the team gained practical, actionable tools and strengthened peer networks—all to drive real, positive impact at our firm.

A standout was the keynote from Dennis Snow, author of *Lessons from the Mouse: A Guide for Applying Disney World's Secrets of Success to Your Organization, Your Career, and Your Life*. Drawing from his Disney experience, he challenged attendees to elevate service by being intentional in every interaction—asking, "Will these words make this person feel truly valued?"—and creating "moments of wow" that exceed expectations. **For our clients, this means warmer, more thoughtful communication, personalized attention that anticipates your needs, and service that consistently**

continued on pg. 12

goes beyond the ordinary to make you feel truly valued and cared for.

Prospera also unveiled **Advisor Gateway**, a modern, long-awaited platform that quickly became a highlight. Built to replace outdated systems, it delivers streamlined workflows, clearer role accountability, and smoother daily operations. The team previewed it in dedicated sessions ahead of the May 2026 launch and is excited to implement it. **For you, this translates to faster account updates, seamless onboarding and maintenance, quicker responses to inquiries, and fewer administrative hurdles—so we can focus even more on what matters most: your financial goals and peace of mind.**



Key Takeaways from Our Team

- **Grace** immersed herself in sessions on client communication, relationship management, and elevating the client experience. Her energy, focus, and rapid mastery of operational best practices earned her the prestigious **Operations Rookie of the Year** award—a well-deserved recognition of her outstanding first-year contributions and tremendous potential. She's already channeling this into refined daily operations and client interactions. **For our clients, Grace's award and fresh approach mean even higher standards of care, more proactive support, and operations that run so smoothly you barely notice them—freeing us to deliver the personalized guidance you deserve.**

- **Laura** strengthened her expertise in client onboarding and account maintenance by diving into advanced platform tools and workflow optimizations. She's implementing immediate changes to boost efficiency and service quality. **This directly benefits you with quicker account setup, smoother transitions, and more efficient handling of your day-to-day needs.**

- **Vinessa** built on her marketing coordination and team support strengths, absorbing innovative service models and forward-thinking practices. She returned re-energized, with insights that reinforce Prospera's commitment to advisor success and exceptional client experiences. **For you, this means more creative, tailored ways we communicate value, stay ahead of opportunities, and ensure every touchpoint reinforces trust and excellence.**

In Dallas, the team fully immersed in Prospera's resources—reconnecting with peers, forging new connections, and gathering insights to continually raise the bar. **Ultimately, this investment in our team's growth and tools means you receive service that's more responsive, innovative, and relentlessly focused on your success—because when our support team excels, you benefit directly.**

I'm incredibly proud of Laura, Grace, and Vinessa for their enthusiasm, dedication, and the tangible improvements they're already driving back at the office. Grace's Rookie of the Year honor reinforces the high standard we hold ourselves to as a team and our continued commitment to growth and excellence. The momentum from SAU is real, and we're excited to keep building on it—together, for you and the secure, prosperous future we're helping you achieve.



The $24 Manhattan Myth: Why Compound Interest Might Have Made the Lenape the Long-Term "Winners"

In 1626, Dutch settler Peter Minuit "purchased" Manhattan Island from the Lenape people in exchange for trade goods valued at 60 Dutch guilders. Popular legend later simplified this to about **$24** worth of beads, tools, cloth, and other items.

The story is often labeled the "worst real estate deal in history," with the Dutch (and later New Yorkers) getting an unbelievable bargain on what became one of the planet's most valuable pieces of land. But let's flip the perspective: What if the Lenape had taken that initial payment and invested it wisely? The math reveals a stunning lesson about patience, time, and compounding.

Enter the **Rule of 72**—a quick, kid-friendly way to estimate how long it takes for money to double at a given annual return:

Years to double ≈ 72 ÷ annual interest rate (as a percentage)

Some easy examples:

- **At 6% annual return: 72 ÷ 6 = 12 years to double.**
- **At 8%: 72 ÷ 8 = 9 years.**
- **At 10%: 72 ÷ 10 = 7.2 years.**

The higher (and steadier) the return, the faster the doublings—and over centuries, the results become mind-boggling!

Let's imagine the Lenape invested that legendary $24 in a diversified, long-term stock market investment (like the S&P 500), earning a realistic average real return of about **7%** per year after inflation—a figure often cited for long-term U.S. equities.

Using the Rule of 72 at 7%:

- Money doubles roughly every **10.3 years** (72 ÷ 7 ≈ 10.3). For simplicity and family conversations, lets round it to **10 years** per doubling.

From 1626 to 2026 is about **400 years**—that's roughly **40 doublings** (400 ÷ 10 = 40).

Starting with just $24:

- **After 10 doublings (~100 years): ~$24,000**
- **After 20 doublings (~200 years): ~$24 million**
- **After 30 doublings (~300 years): ~$24 billion**
- **After 40 doublings (~400 years): ~$24 trillion**

These are not exact calculations to be clear. At a conservative 6%, it still reaches billions; at 8%, it explodes even more. We've just updated the presentation most of you have seen in the past and the actual return for stocks is north of 9% for the last 20 years.

To put that in perspective: The **total value** of Manhattan (referring to the aggregate market value of all real estate, including residential, commercial, office, multifamily, etc.) isn't published as a single, standalone figure for the borough alone in most public sources. However, the most authoritative and recent data comes from the **New York City Department of Finance (DOF)** tentative property tax assessment roll for Fiscal Year 2027 (released in January 2026, reflecting current valuations as of late 2025/early 2026).

NYC's citywide market value is a record **$1.659 trillion** (up 5.4% from the prior year). Manhattan typically accounts for a disproportionately large share due to its concentration of high-value commercial, office, and luxury residential properties, but the raw compounding math shows how a modest sum, left untouched and reinvested over extreme time horizons, can outpace even the most valuable real-world assets.

The real power here is the timeless financial truth: **Time is the ultimate ally in building wealth.** A small amount invested early, consistently, and left to compound can grow into something extraordinary. We won't live for 400 years, of course—but this story resonates for teaching the next generation. Start small and early (even $50–$100), stay invested through ups and downs, avoid touching the principal, and let compounding do its quiet, relentless work. The results can transform lives, build legacies, and open doors for generations to come.



Overcoming Tax Anxiety: Strategies for a Calmer Tax Season

It's often said that the only certainties in life are death and taxes—and as fellow "millionaire next door" types, we truly get it. We've built our success through hard work and smart decisions, paying our fair share along the way. But let's be honest: we've been patriotic enough already, and it's natural to feel stress about optimizing what we owe—legally and effectively—without trouble. As tax season approaches (or nags year-round), that familiar anxiety can hit hard. Here, we'll cover what it is, why it happens, how it shows up, and straightforward ways to manage it—drawn from personal experiences and our work with clients just like you.

What is Tax Anxiety?

That nagging stress, worry, or dread around preparing, filing, or managing taxes. It spikes near deadlines but can linger, especially with complex finances or past IRS issues, often tying into bigger money worries and showing as emotional ups/downs, physical symptoms, or avoidance.

Common Causes

- Ever-changing tax laws leading to second-guessing and fear of errors.
- Procrastination creating last-minute pressure.
- Worries about mistakes, audits, or surprise bills.
- Past penalties or negative IRS experiences.
- Broader pressures like market swings or cash flow ups and downs.

Symptoms

- **Emotional:** Irritability, constant fretting, feeling overwhelmed.
- **Physical:** Headaches, poor sleep, tension, brain fog.
- **Behavioral:** Dodging paperwork, procrastination habits, or low moods.

Coping Strategies

Practical steps to ease the burden:

- **Start early:** Gather docs now and tackle in small steps—no marathon sessions.
- **Get expert help:** Work with a trusted CPA and reliable software; build a year-round partnership to reduce uncertainty and bring us into that conversation.
- **Stay calm:** Use mindfulness, deep breathing, or relaxing music during tasks.
- **Zoom out:** Update your budget and work with us for long-term clarity.
- **File early:** Beat the deadline to dissolve pressure and allow fixes.
- **Stay informed wisely:** Track credible tax updates without overdoing it.

How Speicher Private Wealth Helps Tackle Tax Anxiety

We're in your corner, partnering closely with your CPA through our **VISTA Process**—integrating wealth management, risk/debt strategies, tax planning, estate planning, and more for complete visibility and no blind spots.

We use top tools like **Holistiplan** (ranked #1 tax planning software by advisors for five consecutive years in the T3/Inside Information Survey, including 2025) and **RightCapital** (consistently high-rated for comprehensive, client-friendly planning, with top satisfaction scores in recent Kitces and T3 reports) to spot opportunities, and provide clear insights:

Quick Visibility	Holistiplan analyzes returns in ~45 seconds for visual dashboards and reports; RightCapital aggregates accounts (banks, investments, etc.) for real-time unified views. The secure vault is great for organization.
Real Value	Eliminate manual effort for precise tax forecasts (Holistiplan) and holistic modeling (RightCapital)—like optimized Roth conversions, efficient withdrawals, charitable moves, or estate tweaks.
Easy Explanations	Interactive charts and "what-if" scenarios cut through complexity.
Year-round Personalization	Identify tax savings and custom advice on distributions, Social Security, investments, and more—proactive all year.
Accuracy & Security	Automation reduces errors; robust protections keep data private.
Transparent Support	Clear upfront model, realistic timelines, and focused results.

Bottom line: These tools turn tax time from stressful to efficient and empowering—freeing your mind for what matters.

Final Thoughts

Tax anxiety doesn't have to dominate. With awareness of triggers, these steps, and solid support, you can take control and face taxes confidently. If it's hitting hard, reach out—we're here to help tailor solutions for you.

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Dow 100,000? Is That Possible?

The Dow Jones Industrial Average (DJIA)—a price-weighted index of 30 leading blue-chip U.S. companies across sectors like industrials, finance, tech, healthcare, and consumer staples—made history on February 6, 2026, surging over 1,200 points (2.47%) to close at 50,115.67, its first-ever finish above 50,000. (Many younger investors focus on tech-heavy benchmarks like the Nasdaq or S&P 500, but the Dow's emphasis on established giants like Caterpillar and Goldman Sachs offers a classic pulse on broader economic strength.)

This milestone came less than two years after crossing 40,000 in May 2024, powered by a rotation into old-school names—Caterpillar roaring higher on infrastructure bets, Goldman Sachs riding deal flow—even as tech names shook off early-week jitters.

This hits close to home. When I joined PaineWebber in 1998, the Dow sat around 9,000 (closing the year near 9,181). I've seen it more than quintuple in under 30 years. Those early-war stories—dot-com crash, 9/11, Y2K panic, bird flu/swine flu scares, Ebola, the 2008 meltdown—all hitting in my first decade—now feel like ancient history. Markets keep grinding higher through chaos, proving resilience.

But round numbers like 50,000 still spark euphoria and overreaction. Headlines blared "historic high," floor traders high-fived as the ticker crossed the mark, yet the core lesson holds: these psychological barriers supercharge greed and fear, tripping up even veterans.

Picture Alex Rivera, a fictional 42-year-old civil engineer in Albuquerque, New Mexico. For years he'd quietly built a sturdy portfolio—mostly low-cost index funds plus a handful of Dow names—through automatic payroll deductions and reinvested dividends. By late 2025, with the Dow grinding toward the high 40,000s, the feed exploded: TikTok clips of traders popping champagne, Reddit threads screaming "50K inevitable," friends texting screenshots of Caterpillar calls up 300%. Alex felt the pull hard. Late nights, phone glowing in the dark, he'd refresh his brokerage app, heart racing as positions climbed. "This is the big one," he told himself. Greed whispered promises: early retirement by 55, upgrading the family home, that long-dreamed trip to Europe. FOMO hit like a freight train.



He acted fast—shifted bonds to stocks, opened margin to double down on industrials, even drained part of the emergency fund "just this once" to buy more before it "blasted off." The gains felt electric; every green day fueled visions of financial freedom.

Then reality bit. Early 2026 brought whispers: softening data, sticky inflation, money rotating elsewhere. The Dow dipped 8% in a sharp correction. Alex's leveraged positions cratered overnight. Margin calls lit up his inbox at 3 a.m.; his broker's calm voice on the phone felt like a gut punch. Panic set in—sweaty palms, racing thoughts of 2008 flashbacks. He hit sell at the bottom, crystallizing big losses, then froze in cash, convinced the next crash was imminent. "What if it all evaporates?" he agonized.

By the time the Dow powered back above 50,000 on that euphoric February day, Alex was sidelined, portfolio gutted not by bad companies, but by his own emotional rollercoaster—buying high in greed-fueled frenzy, selling low in terror.

Behavioral finance nails it: greed inflates bubbles by blinding us to risks; fear locks in losses and keeps us out of rebounds—the exact opposite of "buy low, sell high."

The 50,000 mark reflected genuine gains—strong earnings, economic toughness, smart index tweaks—but it changed nothing fundamental. It was a mental milestone that amplified human nature: some chased endless upside, others, scarred by the dip, missed the recovery entirely.

Warren Buffett's line still rings true: "Be fearful when others are greedy, and greedy when others are fearful." Real winning comes from boring discipline—diversify broadly, invest regularly (dollar-cost averaging through storms), avoid leverage traps, trust compounding instead of chasing fireworks.

As the Dow sits above 50,000 and eyes the horizon, the number dazzles but isn't the point. Markets reward patience and emotional control. We win or lose not by the index's march, but by mastering greed and fear. From ~9,000 in 1998 to over 50,000 today, the proof is in: stay steady, and time does the work.

Stay tuned—the next 10 years will be just as wild. Dow 100,000? With discipline, it's within reach. Just don't let emotions derail the ride.



Bobbi's Scalloped Potatoes

To celebrate San Luis Valley potato farmers, here's a comforting recipe garnished with parsley and garlic salt. This creamy classic highlights the earthy tenderness of Colorado's renowned potatoes.

Ingredients (Serves 6-8)



- 3 lbs Yukon Gold or Russet potatoes (San Luis Valley-grown if possible), peeled and thinly sliced (⅛-inch thick)
- 4 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 large onion, thinly sliced
- 3 cloves garlic, minced
- ¼ cup all-purpose flour
- 3 cups whole milk (or half milk, half heavy cream for extra richness)
- 1 tsp garlic salt (plus extra for garnish)
- ½ tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp paprika (optional)
- 2 cups shredded cheddar or Gruyère cheese (divided)
- Chopped fresh parsley (for garnish)

Instructions

1. Preheat oven to 375°F (190°C). Grease a 9x13-inch baking dish.
2. Melt butter in a skillet over medium heat. Add onion and cook until softened (~5 min). Stir in garlic for 1 minute.
3. Whisk in flour and cook 1-2 min to form a light roux.
4. Gradually whisk in milk to prevent lumps. Simmer until thickened (~5 min). Season with garlic salt, pepper, and paprika (if using). Remove from heat and stir in 1½ cups cheese until melted.
5. Layer half the potatoes in the dish; pour half the sauce over. Repeat with remaining potatoes and sauce.
6. Cover with foil and bake 45 min. Uncover, top with remaining ½ cup cheese, and bake 20-30 min more until potatoes are tender and top is golden and bubbly.
7. Let rest 10 min. Garnish with chopped parsley and a light sprinkle of garlic salt.

This cozy dish pairs beautifully with roasted meats, holiday hams, or simple greens—honoring the hardworking San Luis Valley farmers who grow these exceptional potatoes in their high-altitude paradise of sunshine and mountain water.

Tip: Use a mandoline for uniform slices and let the dish rest after baking for perfect creaminess. Enjoy—and thank those Colorado growers!

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